

Storied legacy: The 2018 Commonwealth Games marked Neeraj Chopra's arrival on the national stage, as the then 21-year-old clinched gold in the men's javelin (in pic). Eight years on, he returns to Glasgow as a giant of world athletics. AFP



(right). Outside of last year's World Championships, it was the lowest he had finished at any competition going all the way back to the 2017 World Championships.

At Glasgow, things aren't going to be any easier considering the standard of competition. On paper, there are multiple throwers who would be favoured over Neeraj. Sri Lankan phenom Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, who has thrown 92.62m at the Rome Diamond League this season, will go in as the obvious favourite for gold.

Grenada's Anderson Peters and reigning Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem are also more than capable of producing monster throws. There's competition from India too — Rohit Yadav, whose 87.05m makes him second on this season's world list.

With Neeraj bracing for a tough challenge, the rest of the 32-strong Indian athletics contingent will have their work cut out as they aim to better the eight medals India won in 2022 — one gold, four silver and three bronze.

Of the 23 track and field events that will be contested in Glasgow, there's just one where an Indian has a season's best better than the rest of the confirmed field — the men's long jump, in which Murali Sreeshankar leads with an effort of 8.38m this season.

As the leading athlete among Commonwealth nations, Murali will be looking to improve on the silver he won at the Birmingham Games. Praveen Chithravel, who finished fourth in the triple jump four years ago, is expected to reach the podium this time, with his season's best of



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